

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*When Things Fall Apart ~ Heart Advice for Difficult Times
How to Beat Anxiety*

August 17th, 2025



*Illustration by Lauren Peters-Collaer
Source image by Caspar David Friedrich, 1818*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Hymn Improvisation

Improvisation on *Veni Creator Spiritus* (Improvisation)/

Fuga G-moll, BWV 578 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Invention in C minor (William Joel)

Pièce par Monsieur Babou 1709 (Thomas René Babou) and Improvisation

Three pieces by Ramón Noble

- Toccata

- El Flautista Alegre

- La Bamba

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome & Words of Gathering

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Holy Center of this summer day,
your light shines in our lives;
your peace embraces
our anger, sorrow, and loss;
your life opens us to new discoveries
of our most intimate selves
and of our neighbors,
wherever we may find them.

*In your life, death, and life from death,
we are discovering your unfailing love
and grace, for all our lives!*

In this time, let us seek –
and find your presence in this,
our sacred and set apart, time and place.

May it be so.

*May it be so for us on this day,
and in all the days to come!*

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

From All That Dwell Beneath the Skies

LASST UNS ERFREUEN

From all that dwell below the skies

Let the Creator's praise arise;

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Let the Creator's name be sung

Through every land, in every tongue.

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

In every land begin the song,
To every land the strains belong:
Alleluia! Alleluia!
In cheerful sound all voices raise
And fill the world with joyful praise.
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia!

Eternal are your mercies, God;
Eternal truth attends your word:
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your praise shall sound from shore to shore,
'Till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia!

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Gracious God,
this morning as we gather,
we are all too aware that our hearts are
often closed to the light of your love and mercy.
We do not always love ourselves,
we are angry at our perceived helplessness,
and we feel unmoored as the structures of our society, are in freefall.

*In the past, as we searched for life
we were daring and brave.
But now, we are protecting ourselves
emotionally, socially, and spiritually.
Our worry and fear is feeding
the pain of the world rather than
looking for - and claiming -
the hope that is our destiny.*

This morning, O God,
we ask for your help in opening, loosening,
and unbinding our hearts and our souls.
We ask that you unfreeze our hearts to love,
open our clenched hands to help,
and breathe life into our stifled spirits.
*And then, Life Giving God,
help us to remember that our power is love.
Help us to remember that your strength
will shine like the stars in the night sky
as we work with - and for - all our siblings -
in the present, and for the future.*

May it ever be so.
May we make it so!
Amen and Amen!

[adapt/ duck&tirabassi]

***Introit**

"Gathered Here"
Cathedral Choir

SOUTH AFRICAN CANON

***The Lord's Prayer**

Gavin Gregorio & Esme Gregoropoulos

We are invited to pray in our own tradition and language.

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kindom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kindom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Gavin Gregorio & Esme Gregoropoulos

Fear and anger are such natural human responses.
But they lead so easily to hatred and violence.
It is not the fear and anger that are wrong,
but the way we choose to respond to them.

Today, may we look deep within us for the ways
we allow fear and anger to encumber us,
and may we open our hearts
to the reality of God
as we follow the Way of the Christ.

This morning, may the Deep Peace and Gracious Power of God be with you.
And also with you.

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition
from the Gospel Luke chapter 4 & from the Epistles - Ephesians 4

Rev. Tanaka Pack

For these words of the ancients whose wisdom we welcome in our present,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Litany of Assurance

When my head is aching and my muscles are tense,
you remind me of what is important and what is not.
You have comforted my spirit with your love.

When fatigue confuses my thinking
and clouds my perspective,
you refuel my energies and assure me
that sleep will be coming soon.
You have calmed and quieted my soul.

When illness saps my strength and pain
is a frequent foe,
you tell me I am not alone.
You have comforted my spirit with your love.

When anger closes my throat
and streams of resentment flow over me,
you clear my head and help me to realize
my adversary is also afraid.
You have calmed and quieted my soul.

When sleep will not come at night
and hours crawl by amid financial worry,
you let me know that you are with me.
You have comforted my spirit with your love.

When my shoulders feel weighted down
by the responsibility of family and work,
you offer me your strength so that I may carry on.
You have calmed and quieted my soul.

We give thanks, O God, for all the ways
you work in and through our humanness.
*May we be ever attuned to your presence
in those around us, who offer love and grace.
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

“Cantique de Jean Racine”
Cathedral Choir

GABRIEL FAURE

Word, at one with the Divine, our true hope, eternal day of the earth and heavens, we break the silence of the night; Divine Savior, cast your eyes upon us! Spread over us the light of your powerful grace, that our worries may calm at the sound of your voice; Dispel the slumber of a languishing soul that drives us to forget your compassion. O Christ, show favor to the faithful people now assembled in order to thank you now. Accept the songs we offer to your immortal glory; and may we go forth filled with your gifts.

Message

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Don't Let The Sun Go Down On Me"

ELTON JOHN

Frank Hobbs, Soloist

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Prayer of Offering

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Gracious God, this morning we have been reminded:
Your wall of hope surrounds us in our despair;
your haven of faith welcomes us in our unbelief;
your citadel of love protects us from our anger.

Gracious Word, you reach out to those we would not touch;
you greet those we would ignore;
you welcome those we would exclude;
and you say to them – and to us –
You are my beloved children.

With these gifts of time and money and hope,
we ask for the wisdom we need to live in these days,
as people who are dreaming the future,
with each other - and with you.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Breath, love, hope, inspiration
-truth that sings forth from within
even as we are enveloped with its challenge,
let us be present to these uncharted boundaries
which transcend us.

May these harmonies speak to us
of the beauty for which we long.
May the unremembered perfection
of the original blessing of our birth
and the hallowed music deep within our souls,
pour truth into the crevasses of despair
in our world.

May we walk with courage
in places of hurt, anger, fear, and isolation.

*May love be the standard we bear,
holding us to our own truths.
And may we find, O God,
our way back to one another
and in each other's eyes,
find welcome, healing, and forgiveness.*

[adapt/progressivechristianity]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Ye Shall Have A Song"
Laude

RANDALL THOMPSON

*Hymn for the Journey

Come, See the Fullness

BUNESSAN

God the Creator gave in abundance
All of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty,
Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given;
Beauty and promise, mystr'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.
Open your hearts wide, teach us your wisdom
Lest our days pass by empty and small.
May we be witness with your creation –
To your great kindness given to all.

-lyrics by Peggy Haymes

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence
Toccatina - Reprise (Ramón Noble)

Inside The Music

“Faure’s “Cantique de Jean Racine” has been a choral top ten classic for decades. It’s persistent lilting accompaniment line settles into the soul, calming as it meanders through rich 19th century harmonies. The text, by renowned 17th century playwright Jean Racine, raises questions about that calm. It’s as if the piece begins midway through a moment of anxiety. The voice of humanity has been agitated by something larger than can be managed, yet, has found its way to slumbering rather than addressing that which is before it. The calming accompaniment reminds us of that release that is both blessed in some ways and empty in others. When the choir enters, we are brought into focus. We call to the voice of the divine to speak and shed light on this moment that we are unable to manage alone. The choir sings lush, long phrases. They are plaintive, but sweet. We know that there are answers, if difficult to find. We sing with gratitude infused with hope. Once a call for help has been heard, we address our own role in the action. The music swells as the choir calls to the divine to dispel our desire for slumber that makes us forget compassion. We till the soil of the soul seeking motivation. As quickly as the swell occurs, the choir settles back into the calming river of divine light. The piece ends in gratitude. Aware now of our unity with the divine, we offer songs and thanks. Faure’s musical sweetness fills the air with warmth in the midst of a text that could be much more charged. He calls us to acknowledge that fear and anxiety, though part of the human experience, can always find a resting place. As we recognize our oneness with divinity, and our capacity to gather in beloved community, we can embrace answers beyond those that would cause us to check out of life. We can find motivation through compassion into new ways of living.” – Dr. David Harris

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